

« Everyone has their own story; it's about how you write it »

DHRUV JUREL

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On a scorching Sunday afternoon at a cafe in Jaipur, Dhruv Jurel, the young wicketkeeper-batter, is gracefully balancing his mealtime with fan interactions — signing autographs, and posing for selfies.

Debating in the 4-1 Test series win against England at home, Jurel's composure under pressure underscored his readiness for the big stage. Yet he remains grounded, attributing his success to the unwavering backing of his IPL team, Rajasthan Royals.

Spotted and nurtured by the franchise three seasons ago, Jurel honed his skills under the guidance of Zubin Bharucha, the High-Performance Director.

As the son of a Kargil war veteran, Jurel's focus on continuous improvement defines his approach. The 23-year-old from Agra wants to repay Rajasthan Royals' faith in him.

Can you summarise your journey from being a rookie to earning a Test cap for India in the past year?

It was an unexpected journey. After being on the bench for a season, I made my debut for Rajasthan Royals in 2023, and to be honest, I was not thinking too far ahead. My only target was to play as many matches as possible in the IPL and make my team win. So, I would prepare for about eight to nine hours a day, even during the off-season. I knew that I couldn't be thinking about what can happen in the future, but I focused on keeping myself ready for any opportunity.

Since my father was in the Indian Army, I always wanted to join the Armed Forces or the Indian Navy, but that did not happen. Since then, I wanted to serve the nation by playing cricket.

So yes, the last year has made me realise *kahan se kahan leke jaati hai zindagi* (you never know where life takes you), and all I have is gratitude. The journey has not only boosted my confidence but has also made me understand that one should never shy away from working hard. The rest will follow.

It's a great feeling to have played Test cricket for India. For me, it's the

ultimate format of the game, and there's a sweetness to it: as you play over five days, you can never take things easy, and when the hard work that the team puts in over the five days gets rewarded with a win, you feel the happiest.

In the England Test series, your strong wicketkeeping and batting earned praise, while banter with teammate Sarfaraz Khan unsettled the visiting team...

(Laughs) Those are normal things. As a wicketkeeper, it's my job to gauge the batter's movement and accordingly alert the bowlers. But in Dharamsala, it was Sarfaraz who predicted that Ollie Pope would step out, and that assessment helped both me and Kuldeep (Yadav).

As a batter, I have realised that while at the crease, if someone constantly talks behind your back, you sort of lose your concentration. So, we adopted a similar approach. The aim was to irritate the English batters by constantly talking. *Thoda kaan khana* (Being in someone's ears) is good at times because it not only breaks the batter's